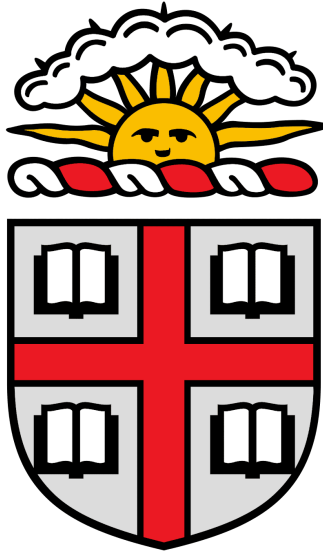


**Those are Fighting Words: Utilizing Populist Language as a
Predictor in US Election Models**



by

George Weiler

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Thesis Advisor: Dr. Uriel Cohen Priva
Concentration Advisor: Dr. Steven Sloman

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ABSTRACT

This study investigates the predictive power of populist language in U.S. Congressional elections ranging from 2016 to 2024. Using a sample of 183 candidates across 519 elections, a linear mixed-effects regression used populist language features and control variables to predict election outcomes as measured by “Win Above Replacement” (WaR). The question was whether the semantic components (people-centric language, anti-elitism, anti-intellectual language) or the emotionality of populism were predictive of election performances. Results showed that emotionality, not semantic framing, was predictive of outcomes. In a combined model of both parties, emotion was significant ($\beta = 1.282$, $p = 0.002$) while the semantic composite was not ($\beta = 1.106$, $p = 0.183$). Party affiliation moderated these effects: Republicans showed a significant emotion effect ($\beta = 0.999$, $p = 0.038$), while Democrats showed none ($\beta = 1.010$, $p = 0.267$). District competitiveness further conditioned Democratic effects—emotion significantly predicted performance in swing districts ($\beta = 2.681$, $p = 0.015$) but not in safe districts. Test-set validation showed moderate predictive validity ($r = 0.291$ – 0.300 for both parties). These findings suggest that emotional rhetoric, not policy substance or ideological framing, drives electoral success, and that this relationship varies by party affiliation and electoral context.

LITERATURE REVIEW

This literature review analyzes the existing literature on populism to address the question: Can populism and its linguistic features drive electoral success? While the definition of “populism” is ill-defined and subject to disagreement, scholars generally agree that it is a “thin ideology” with a closely associated semantic style (Moffitt & Tormey, 2014; Stanley, 2008). That style generally includes both semantic features (people-centric, anti-elite, anti-intellectual language) and emotional features (anger- or anxiety-inducing language).

However, no research to date has examined how this populist communication style influences voter behavior and shapes election outcomes. This review synthesizes the literature on populism as performance, the linguistic mechanisms of populist communication, and the behavioral effects of semantic versus emotional language. It then identifies the empirical gap addressed by this dissertation.

I. What is Populism?

Despite decades of research, there remains no consensus on what populism is. In fact, the only agreement lies in the inherent disagreement over how to define populism (Moffitt & Tormey, 2014). While it is important to acknowledge the disagreement in the literature, this disagreement makes the study of populism difficult. When one author operationalizes populism as a belief system (Mudde, 2004; Kjeldgaard-Christiansen, 2024) and others as performances (Moffitt & Tormey, 2014; Canovan, 1999), bridging the gap to create a unified theory becomes impossible. How can studies of populism as an ideology have any relevance to the studies of populism as a style? The goal here is to solidify a definition of populism that is usable for political linguistics research.

Most authors agree that populism comprises two major components: an anti-establishment belief system and a rhetorical style (Mudde, 2004). The issue is that the literature assumes these are two independent components that, in combination, form a complete picture of populist ideology. However, measuring an internal belief system poses problems. First, how do we measure an abstract set of beliefs? There is no way to detect or quantify beliefs, so this aspect of ideology is inherently unmeasurable. Second, does the internal aspect actually *matter* when studying populism? While there are some areas where it is necessary to measure one's convictions (such as studies of political alignment), the study of how politicians utilize ideology focuses more on the external expression of beliefs than on the internal belief system. Because of this, this study operationalizes populism as a 'thin ideology,' focusing on the rhetorical and communicative features through which it is publicly performed.

The idea of populism as a "thin ideology" is relatively common throughout the political science literature. Some authors frame this as discourse rather than ideology (Laclau, 2005), while others view it as a belief system with a closely associated rhetorical style (Mudde, 2004; Kjeldgaard-Christiansen, 2024). These various descriptions all support the idea that the performative features of populism are central to the ideology. Therefore, to study populism, we must examine how it is practiced and communicated, rather than searching for some 'authentic' ideology beneath the rhetoric.

Perceptions of ideology are constructed through the absorption of words and actions. One would strongly defend the claim that Donald Trump is a populist because of the way he speaks and the performance he exhibits, despite a suspicion that he is, in fact, an elitist. In this way, populism seems to be externally measured by the performance one exhibits.¹ This ties into the idea that populism is a 'thin ideology' – lacking content and instead relying solely on rhetoric

¹ This idea of "ideology as performance" has roots in Butler's concept of gender as performance. Butler (1990) contends that identity (and specifically, gender identity) is not an abstract trait we possess but rather a collection of gender performances we enact. This is the argument for ideology as performance. Butler says that "because gender is not a fact, the various acts of gender create the idea of gender, and without those acts, there would be no gender at all" (1988). This same principle applies to ideology. 'Populism' is not a fact of life; it is created through the consistent acts of populism by actors. The performance of such populist acts is what labels someone a populist.

(Moffitt & Tormey, 2014; Stanley, 2008). One could argue that populism is not unique in this regard and that other ideologies could be defined in the same way. However, for the purposes of this study, it is sufficient to say that populism has a characteristic external expression.

This claim, that political ideologies are defined by performance, has roots in linguistic theory outlined by J.L. Austin. We understand that words can constitute actions. For example, the utterance “I do” at a wedding is, in and of itself, the action that begins a marriage. When words are performances, they constitute actions. Taken together, those accumulated performances constitute an ideology. When Moffitt and Tormey describe populism as a performance, they mean that it consists solely of a politician's words and actions. Some underlying belief, such as the conviction that elites are ‘evil’, is not a necessary component of the definition; the performance is sufficient.

When using the term “thin ideology,” Moffitt and Tormey are describing ideologies where the “‘aesthetic’ or ‘performative’ features are particularly (and increasingly) important.” Notably, this paper was written in 2014, before the launch of Donald Trump’s transformative 2016 presidential campaign. I would argue that one of the most significant contributions of his political career has been the increasing emphasis on the aesthetic features of politics across the political spectrum (Bonikowski, 2022). Since Moffitt and Tormey published their paper, the landscape has changed dramatically. This change illuminates that performance has always been central to ideology. The purely ‘aesthetic’ qualities are more prominent now than ever before.

The idea of ideology as performance is hinted at indirectly in much of the literature. Any papers that discuss populism as ‘rhetorical style’ (Laclau, 2005; Canovan, 1999), a ‘thin ideology’ (Moffitt & Tormey, 2014; Stanley, 2008), or a combination of substance and style (Mudde, 2004; Kjeldgaard-Christiansen, 2024), understand that actions and words constitute ideology, even if they do not explicitly theorize it as performance. Notably, the literature lacks

attempts to understand populism as a neurological phenomenon or an ontological belief system; rather, it regards ideologies as no deeper than their public performance.

Synthesizing populism as a “thin ideology” that consists of words and actions not only aligns with the literature, but it also makes the study of populism simpler. When we study the populist ideology through its rhetorical style, it becomes quantifiable. Conceptualizing populism as a rhetorical device is central to this study's methodology, in which populism is operationalized through the linguistic features that constitute its public expression.

II. Components of the Populist Performance

Moffitt and Tormey say that populist style is characterized by three main pillars: an appeal to the people, an imminent crisis, and “bad manners.” An appeal to the common people and ‘bad manners’ are commonly cited components of populism in the literature. The third – imminent crisis – is less common. Before dissecting the meaning of imminent crisis, we can start by refining Moffitt and Tormey's other pillars.

First, the use of ‘bad manners’ is a common technique in populist performances, employed to distinguish the populist from the elite and to signal distrust of the establishment. By defying cultural norms, they demonstrate that they are not subservient to a system that exploits the common people (Stanley, 2008). This also serves an important purpose in contemporary politics, where academia and intellectualism are commonly cited as “out of touch” with the common people (Gerstlé & Nai, 2019). In populist performances, ‘bad manners’ serve to demonstrate in-group belonging and hostility toward oppressive cultural norms.

The populist uses people-centric language for two core purposes: to create a morally superior in-group and to associate themselves with that group (Moffitt & Tormey, 2014; Gerstlé & Nai, 2019; Oliver & Rahn, 2016; Abts & Rummens, 2007). This is essential to the populist performance. The word populism is, itself, an appeal to the people. Populists claim to represent

the typical person in a given society and offer them political power in exchange for their support. By centering an abstract “people” in their language, populists signal their belonging. It is well documented that humans are group-centered creatures and tend to favor members of their own group (Everett et al., 2015). People-centric language exploits this tendency, defining the average person in a politically beneficial way that puts the populist in a favorable in-group position.

However, in-groups are only as strong as their opposition. Moffitt and Tormey are reluctant to admit that an essential part of populism is inherently the juxtaposition of the people against the elites, instead opting for ‘crisis’ as the stand-in for the elite out-group. They do admit, however, that in populist performances, the elite are often at the center of the crisis, and that populists will consider themselves ‘distinct’ from the elite. But what is an in-group without its complement?

Rather than describing a specific crisis, Gerstlé and others describe populists as attacking the elites. Indeed, this appears more specific than what Moffitt describes. Rather than an amorphous crisis, they identify corrupt elites at its center. This crisis can be one of national identity (Gerstlé & Nai, 2019; Abts & Rummens, 2007) or one of corruption and theft (Oliver & Rahn, 2016). Regardless, the essential component that they add to Moffitt and Tormey’s definition is the complementary “them” to populism’s inherent “us”. If populists are people-centric, they must also create an opposing group. That group is the corrupt elites. Thus, rather than simply using a vague “threat”, populism is defined by anti-elitism that targets the people and institutions that pose a threat to the people.

Together, these three refined pillars show the semantic picture of the populist performance. Populists create an in-group with people-centric language, and oppose that with an out-group of elites targeted by anti-elitist rhetoric. They also tend to use anti-intellectual language, a rhetorical strategy that makes them seem both plainspoken and anti-establishment.

But what is missing is the sense of urgency captured by Moffitt and Tormey's "crisis". While targeting elites captures the same semantic element, there seems to be an emotional charge to a crisis that is absent in this definition of populist performance. Something exists in the populist style beyond the semantic qualities.

Gerstlé and Nai identify a similar construct in their paper, which they call "emotionality". However, their emotionality is defined as distinct from the populist performance. This seems simplistic. A performance cannot simply consist of semantic traits. A layman reading a script, emotionless, does not have the same effect on the listener as a trained actor inflicting the script with emotion. In the populist performance, this is also the case. Emotionality must be a part of any performance. The specific populist emotionality is one of "ontological insecurity" (Bonansinga, 2020). This insecurity of the self creates emotions in the listener that complement the combative nature of the semantic performance. When corrupt elites exploit the common people, the people must defend their own security. When one feels insecure in the present moment, they tend to project fear and anxiety onto the future. That insecurity-induced anxiety leads people to easily attach to politicians who offer an out through high-energy, hot emotions, like anger or frustration (Bonansinga, 2020).

That anxiety is important. Anxiety is an essential tool in populist performance and political motivation. When anxiety is triggered in a listener, they are more willing to accept novel political views as their own (Marcus et al., 2005). Thus, we cannot separate the semantic qualities of the populist performance from the emotional ones. Instead, these bridge together to create a concrete and cohesive definition: *Populism is a performance that uses anti-intellectual language to pit the common people against corrupt elites, triggering emotional states that tap into listeners' insecurities.*

III. Rhetoric and the Brain

The question now is how populism's performance affects voter behavior. In the populist performance, as I define it, two distinct components compete for relevance: the semantic components (people-centric language, anti-elite language, and anti-intellectual “bad manners”) and the emotional quality (anxiety- and anger-inducing language that targets insecurities).

Research has shown that both language components and emotionality can predict election performance and media coverage in global campaigns (Gerstlé & Nai, 2019). However, the mechanisms underlying this predictive quality remain unanswered. Gerstlé and Nai found in their paper that negative language and emotions are “significantly and substantially drive media coverage and electoral results.” However, populist rhetoric had only a modest impact on the results. This finding raises the question: why does negative language influence election outcomes, whereas populist rhetoric does not? Notably, their study was a global comparative study of candidates across Europe. It is possible that these results do not directly translate into the United States’ political landscape.

Regardless, there is well-documented evidence that language plays an important role in shaping behavior and thought. Issue framing, for example, shifts our representation of issues to change real-life behavior (Thibodeau & Boroditsky, 2011). Even simple metaphors that frame social issues can have a greater impact on behavior and belief systems than party affiliation. The influence of metaphor on thought could substantially affect voter behavior. When a populist performs and cultivates anti-elite sentiment, their language can shape how voters perceive their leaders. That change in thought could drive a change in vote.

Beyond simply reshaping our opinions, research has shown that language can subconsciously drive behavior. When exposed to language that describes the elderly or portrays rudeness, individuals tend to behave in ways that reinforce stereotypes associated with those traits (Bargh et al., 1996). If this is the case, we would expect exposure to populist language to

trigger anti-establishment behavior (such as voting for outsider candidates). These papers suggest that populist rhetoric shapes voter behavior.

But the spoken word is not the whole picture. Emotion is understood to significantly influence behavior. If an essential part of the populist performance is emotionality, we can ask how emotion affects behavior. Populism focuses on inducing insecurity and anxiety through emotions like anger and hatred (Bonansinga, 2020). Anxiety, in particular, has been shown to influence political thought. When exposed to anxiety, people are more willing to accept novel political views (Marcus et al., 2005). This openness, fostered by anxiety, is important for populists, as it creates a context in which their semantics (anti-elite, people-centric) are accepted by listeners when mediated by emotion.

Mediation is necessary for the adoption of these populist behaviors. If the goal of populist politicians is to win voters, they must influence voters' behavior through their words. But words alone do not sway actions. Instead, words have their intended effect only when mediated by emotion and anxiety (Brader et al., 2008). A populist performance centered on anxiety suggests that the emotional content of populism also shapes voters' behavior.

The research shows that both semantics and emotionality should predict election performance. However, the specifics are notably absent. However, there remains a critical empirical gap. While Gerstlé and Nai found that, globally, emotionality and language can drive election results, they did not separate semantic dimensions (people-centrism, anti-elitism, anti-intellectualism) from affective dimensions (anger, anxiety) within populist rhetoric itself. Can we say that populism is not predictive if we have not examined the qualities that constitute it?

Furthermore, no study has examined the predictive power of populist rhetoric in the United States. The US political landscape has undergone significant shifts during the Trump era, and further research on the effects of populism is necessary. It is possible, for example, that populism is more predictive of election outcomes now in the US than it was globally in 2019.

This research addresses this gap by examining whether semantic dimensions of populist rhetoric (people-centrism, anti-elitism, anti-intellectualism), emotional dimensions (anger, anxiety), or both predict electoral success in U.S. elections from 2016 to 2024.

IV. Research Questions

In light of the literature gap, I proposed the central research question: Which dimensions of populist rhetoric (semantic or emotional) are predictive in U.S. elections?

RQ1: Which dimensions of populist language predict electoral success?

Specifically, do the semantic dimensions (people-centrism, anti-elitism, anti-intellectualism), emotional dimensions (anger, anxiety), or both correlate with candidate performance in House elections?

Hypothesis 1a: The semantic components will not significantly predict of electoral success.

Hypothesis 1b: The emotional components will be significant predictors of electoral success.

RQ2: Does the predictive power of populist rhetoric vary by context?

Does the predictive power of populist performance vary across contexts, including time, location, and party affiliation?

Hypothesis 2a: The predictive power of populist rhetoric will decrease over time

Hypothesis 2b: Populist rhetoric will generally be more predictive in competitive districts.

Hypothesis 2c: Republicans will see stronger effects from populist language than Democrats.

DATA AND METHODS

The goal of this research was to understand how language, as an essential component of the populist style, influences the electoral performance of candidates across the political spectrum. A preliminary study was conducted, which established language as predictive, but the study's scope and sample size was limited². Here, I expand on the findings from the previous study, using a combined corpus-linguistics and political modeling approach. The study uses Twitter/X data to construct a corpus of politicians public language, and uses that language as a predictor of election outcomes.

I. Candidate Selection

For both parties, a random number generator was used to select 100 candidates from a wide distribution of districts. First, a state was selected by a number from 1 to 50, and then a district number was generated for that state. Candidates were then cross-checked to account for random overrepresentation. Some candidates lacked publicly available Twitter data. After filtering, the dataset included 92 Republican candidates across 263 elections and 91 Democrats across 256 elections (Appendix A1). Breakdown by party and year can be found below (Figure 1).

Test data was selected using a similar methodology, collecting a total of 30 Democrats and 30 Republicans across the same period, totalling X elections. The methodology differed slightly, as a smaller set was used. To ensure that the smaller set was representative, hand-selection was done after generating the candidate list, adjusting for a representative distribution across PVI and ideology. Again, some candidates were missing publicly available

² The preliminary study can be found in the data files in the "Other Materials" folder.

Twitter data for some years, leading to a smaller final dataset. Details on manual redistribution and missing data can be found in Appendix A5, and a breakdown by party and year can be seen in Figure 2 below.

Fig. 1: Candidate-Elections by Year

	Democrats (91 Candidates)	Republicans (92 Candidates)	Total (183 Candidates)
2016	30	28	58
2018	47	44	91
2020	61	60	121
2022	64	69	133
2024	54	62	116
Total	256	263	519

Fig. 2: Test Set Candidate-Elections by Year

	Democrats (30 Candidates)	Republicans (30 Candidates)	Total (60 Candidates)
2016	3	6	9
2018	5	8	13
2020	7	7	14
2022	8	10	18
2024	14	17	31
Total	37	48	85

II. Variable Selection

Each candidate's election has a collection of variables that are used to predict their election performance. The collection of these variables was standardized to allow for comparison between parties and between the training and test sets.

Dependent Variable

The dependent variable of an election-performance model must always be a metric of how well a candidate performed. I was presented with two options: a binary win/lose measure or a percentage-based "performance" measure.

For this study, a percentage-based metric was selected for two reasons. First, with highly gerrymandered districts, most congressional elections in the United States are predetermined by geography. A binary dependent variable tells us more about the makeup of a district than it does about the traits of the candidate. Second, a "loser" could also have overperformed— a nuance that is missing in a binary. For example, a Republican running in New York City will always lose. But if they are expected to lose by 30 points and only lose by 10, that shows strong performance. A win/lose dependent variable would call the 30-point and 10-point losses equal.

Specifically, I used the Win Above Replacement (WaR) metric created by Split-Ticket Voting, which measures performance relative to expectations. Expectation values are determined by two factors: the district's previous voting record in the previous presidential election and the incumbency levels of the candidates. They then subtract the actual election results from that predicted value, resulting in a -100 to 100 scalar variable that shows the nuance of election performance. The WaR shows how well a candidate performed *relative to expectations*, making data from safe districts equally as relevant as data from competitive ones.

Independent Variables

The experimental component of this research is language and performance. Therefore, the independent variables are the semantic and affective language quantifications collected via the corpus. The corpus comprises tweets from all 183 candidates across the election years 2016-2024. Twitter data was collected using the Twitter-Scraper-Lite API, collecting the 100 most recent Tweets before each election between September 1st and Election Day.³ Sentiment analysis was performed on each tweet using a Claude AI model trained for this purpose (Appendix A2). Claude was trained using a prompt detailing the rating process for each of the four populist rhetoric pillars outlined in the background, and created a corpus of 42,127 Tweets (19,829 Republican; 21,779 Democratic) with ratings for each rhetorical dimension (Appendix A3).

All four are Likert-scale variables coded on a 1-7 scale and then centered from 0 to 6 for the sake of interpretation (a score of 0 means the absence of the trait). Modeling was done for each candidate-election, with each candidate's election treated as a unique datapoint.

For each candidate election, the scores of each tweet were averaged to create a mean score. The result is a measure for “mean emotion,” “mean anti-intellect,” and so on. The three semantic dimensions (people-centrism, anti-elitism, and anti-intellectualism) were averaged into a single composite to reduce multicollinearity, yielding two main predictors: emotional charge and the semantic composite. Combined, these two factors yield a quantifiable metric for the populist performance, as well as independent metrics to test whether the language or emotional content is more influential.⁴

I opted to use the mean as the aggregation technique for combining candidate-election corpus data. There were two main options for this methodology: the mean score for each metric

³ The custom orchestrator can be found on Apify ([thrilled_quibble/twittercorpusbuilder](https://github.com/thrilled_quibble/twittercorpusbuilder)), and all code is available on GitHub at github.com/gweiler441/CPSY_Thesis_API

⁴ This methodology, using language as a predictor, was inspiring in part by Kirk A. Hawkins' paper "Is Chavez Populist?" where a wholistic reading of an utterance is used to determine its political and populist sentiment and content.

across all tweets from that year, and a “percent above” method, which calculates what percentage of the tweets from a given year meet a certain threshold. These two methods measure distinct things: mean measures the intensity of the populist language, how strong they are *on average*. The “percent above” measures prevalence, or how often a candidate uses strong language. Mean was chosen as the primary aggregation method because the model had a stronger fit (AIC = 1510 compared to AIC = 1526). However, I also explore what would happen if a percent-based aggregation were used, seeing as there was some clustering in the variables (Appendix 04).

Control Variables

The control variables are non-experimental measures considered in elections, ranging from district-level statistics to candidate attributes to national trends. These are explained in detail below. Importantly, because incumbency is a significant element of the WaR model, including it on both the left and right sides would complicate the model. All variables were centered around their means for the sake of interpretation.

- 1) **Partisan Voter Index (PVI):** District-level partisanship was measured using the Cook Political Report's Partisan Voter Index, which calculates historical voting trends to determine how far each district leans toward either major party.
- 2) **Turnout:** District-level turnout was calculated as the percentage of votes cast divided by the Citizen Voting Age Population (CVAP), obtained from the MIT Election Lab. CVAP data were available through 2023; 2023 values were used for the 2024 elections due to marginal year-to-year changes.

- 3) **Campaign Fundraising:** Two fundraising variables were included. The total amount raised was log-transformed to account for the wide range (from near zero to millions of dollars). The percentage of funds raised from Political Action Committees (PACs) was also included as a measure of funding source. Both variables were extracted from Federal Election Commission data.
- 4) **National Visibility:** Twitter followers at the time of data collection served as a proxy for candidates' national visibility, manually collected from each candidate's Twitter account.
- 5) **Primary Challenge:** Primary opposition was coded as a binary variable (1 = faced a primary challenger, 0 = no primary challenge), obtained from Ballotpedia. Write-in candidates were not counted as challengers.
- 6) **Control of Congress:** Whether Republicans held majority control of Congress in the election cycle was coded as a binary variable (1 = Republican control, 0 = otherwise).
- 7) **Presidential Election Year:** Presidential election years (2016, 2020, 2024) were coded as 1, non-presidential years as 0, to account for higher turnout and down-ballot effects in presidential cycles.

For Republicans, there was one additional metric: **Trump endorsement**. This measured whether a candidate received an endorsement from Donald Trump in a given election cycle, and was coded as a binary variable (1 = endorsed; 0 = not endorsed), using Ballotpedia data.

III. Statistical Approach

The models in these studies use linear mixed-effects regression (LMER) rather than standard linear regression. The benefit of a mixed-effects model is that it allows for random intercepts. Some candidates are stronger than others. Using LMER allows grouping by candidate and creates random intercepts to account for those innate differences in strength.

The methodology for these models is drawn from the work of Patrick Hummel and David Rothschild in their paper "Fundamental models for forecasting elections at the state level." They develop predictive models based on fundamental variables to forecast outcomes in local elections, including gubernatorial and Senate races. Rather than using polling data, they rely on district-level and candidate-level information to predict election outcomes. The key difference between my methods and theirs is that they predict binary win/loss outcomes, whereas I predict relative performance using WaR. While this adds depth to my model, it also decreases the explanatory power.

First, two LMER models were fitted: a baseline and an experimental model. This was used to test the predictive power of the semantic predictors. The baseline model consisted of the control variable only, while the experimental model included the populist performance metrics as predictors. Then, a temporal LMER was fitted to examine the slopes of the corpus variables across election periods. Finally, additional testing was performed to test relationships between candidates and emotion. Each candidate had a random intercept, representing their "baseline" predicted WaR, controlling for no other factors. This is a measure of how "strong" or "weak" a candidate is inherently, without the compounding effects of the independent and control variables. The final test correlates this value to populist language usage. If higher intercepts correlate with the use of populist rhetoric, then populist rhetoric is simply a byproduct of unmeasured candidate strength. Lack of correlation would indicate that populist language has universal predictive value across candidates of varying strength.

While these original models used mean-based aggregation to combine corpus data into candidate elections, there was something interesting about the effect of a different aggregation strategy. To compare this, the same data were re-aggregated using the percent-above strategy, counting the number of tweets by the candidate that scored 4 or higher on the Likert scale. Then, the models were re-run using the new aggregation to compare those effects.

Finally, the individual party datasets were merged into a single combined-party dataset to test the interaction between parties and populism. The only issue in combined testing was the “Trump Endorsed” metric for Republicans. Democrats are not endorsed by Donald Trump, and therefore could not reasonably score either a 1 or 0 for that metric. To solve this, “Trump Endorsed” was removed as a variable for the combined model.

RESULTS

The findings are outlined in three distinct phases of research: 1) Republican Party models, 2) Democratic Party models, and 3) combined-party modeling. For each party, separate “baseline” and “experimental” models were run for comparison, with baseline models containing only control variables and experimental models including the corpus quantifiers. The results below detail findings for each party.

I. Republican Results

Finding One: Emotion Predicts Performance

Republican results strongly replicated those from the preliminary study. The experimental model showed that emotion was strongly associated with performance ($\beta = 0.999$, $p = 0.038$, $SE = 0.478$). For every one-point in average emotion score in an election year, a candidate sees a one-point increase in WaR (Fig. 5). Since WaR is a measure of relative

performance, a one-point increase is large, roughly one quarter of the standard deviation of WaR (Appendix B4). Also significant were the percentage of PAC money raised ($\beta = 0.051$, $p = 0.003$, $SE = 0.017$) and the district's PVI ($\beta = -0.153$, $p = 0.0002$, $SE = 0.040$).

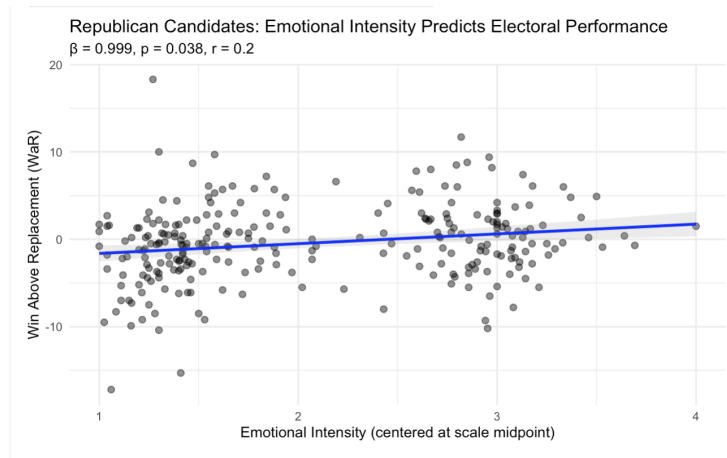
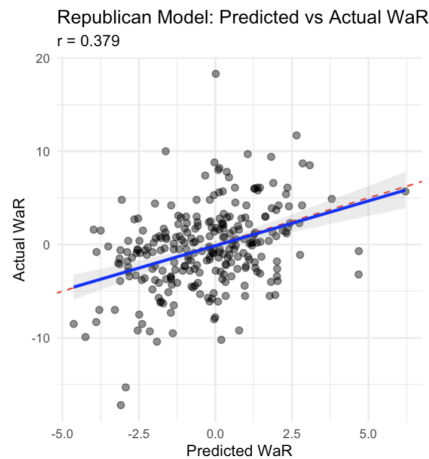
Further, the explanatory power of the experimental model was stronger than the baseline, with a marginal R^2 of 0.143 compared to 0.126. This increase shows that when accounting for emotion, the model explains an additional 2% of variance in results. A table of findings is shown below (Fig. 3), and the full model outputs are in Appendix B1.

This model predicted WaR values somewhat accurately, although variance in uncontrollable variables (such as candidate quality or unquantifiable district attributes) makes these political models inherently noisy (Fig. 4). The relationship between emotion and WaR is also illustrated in the graph below⁵ (Fig. 5). While the slope is relatively small, it demonstrates a significant positive relationship and could predict election outcomes in close districts.

Fig. 3: Outputs of Experimental Republican Model

Models	Conditional R^2	Marginal R^2	Emotion (β)	Emotion (p)	Composite (β)	Composite (p)
Baseline	0.126	0.528	—	—	—	—
Experiemental	0.143	0.536	0.999	0.038*	1.398	0.160
Preliminary	0.194	0.512	3.03	0.044*	-0.21	0.919

⁵ Notably, figure five displays the emotional intensity compared to WaR. That graph appears to show that emotional intensity clusters around two main points: low emotion (1.5 on the Likert scale) and moderate emotion (3 on scale).

Fig. 4: Predicted vs Actual WaR (Appendix B5)**Fig. 5: Emotional Intensity Predicts WaR (Appendix B6)**

Finding Two: Emotion Temporal Effect

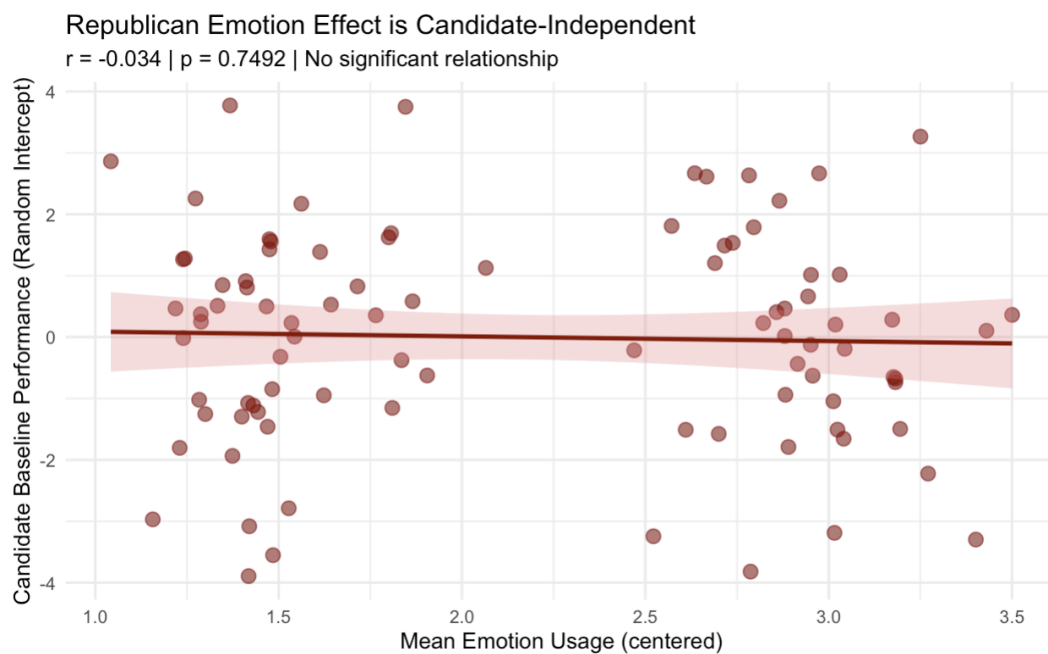
The preliminary study's results indicated a negative temporal relationship between emotion and WaR: over time, emotion's predictive power declined in the previous study. However, running the same test with this larger dataset showed that the temporal relationship was not significant, and flipped directionally ($\beta = 0.256, p = 0.257$). This demonstrates that there is no change in populism's effectiveness over time (Appendix B7).

Finding Three: Random Intercept and Emotion

To test whether populist language is a proxy for inherent candidate strength, the relationship between candidate random intercepts and mean emotional language use was examined. First, candidates were sorted by random intercept, and the top and bottom ten were assessed by emotion and semantic scores (Appendix B6). Then, intercepts were plotted against mean emotional charge to assess a statistical correlation between the two values, which would indicate overlap. Candidate random intercepts and mean emotional charge were not

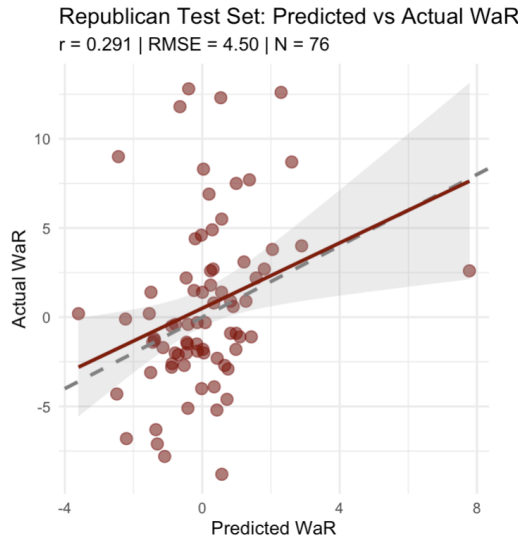
significantly correlated ($r = -0.034$, $p = 0.749$), indicating that populist language benefits candidates of varying baseline strength.

Fig. 6: Random Intercept and Emotion



Finding Four: Bootstrap Testing

To test the generalizability of these results, the final model was used to predict outcomes for test-set candidates. These predictions were then validated using bootstrapping (Appendix E1). The model showed moderate predictive validity on the test set ($r = 0.291$, $RMSE = 4.50$). Predictions clustered around the population mean, indicating that while the model captured directional effects, candidate-level random effects and unobserved factors account for substantial variance in electoral performance.

Fig. 7: Test Set Predicted vs Actual WaR (Appendix E2)

Finding Five: Percent-Based Aggregation

Testing the alternative aggregation technique on the full dataset led to surprising results. While emotion was significant in the original model, the percent-based aggregation model saw a flip: emotion lost significance, and the semantic component became significant (Fig. 8). This significance was not large enough to matter, with the significance level barely above relevance and the slope approaching zero. It demonstrates that the aggregation technique influences the interpretation of the data and, consequently, the model's results.

Fig. 8: Percent-Based Aggregation (Appendix B2)

	Coefficient	Standard Error	p-Value
Emotion	0.011	0.011	0.322
Semantic	0.065	0.039	0.090

II. Democrat Results

Finding One: Populism Has No Effect

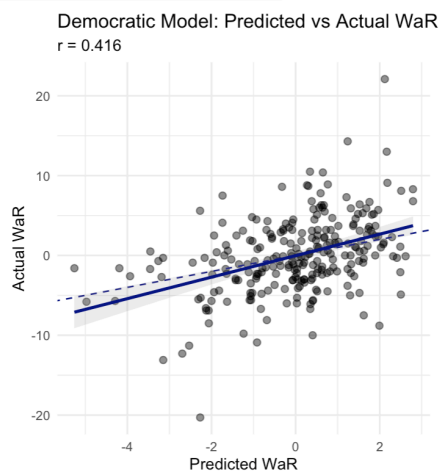
The Democratic results differed strongly from the Republican model. Neither the semantic ($\beta = 0.760$, $p = 0.699$, $SE = 1.962$) nor emotional ($\beta = 1.010$, $p = 0.267$, $SE = 0.909$) qualities of speech were relevant predictors. Additionally, adding emotional and semantic measures to the baseline model did not substantially improve model fit (marginal $R^2 = 0.700$ vs. 0.701), indicating that rhetorical variables do not significantly predict electoral performance for this party (Fig. 8).

Only one of the control variables, primary challenge, was significant ($\beta = -1.242719$, $p = 0.014$, $SE = 0.505$), indicating that having a challenger in a primary is associated with a one-point decrease in WaR.

Fig. 9: Outputs of Experimental Democratic Model (Appendix C1)

Models	Conditional R^2	Marginal R^2	Emotion (β)	Emotion (p)	Composite (β)	Composite (p)
Baseline	0.149	0.701	—	—	—	—
Experimental	0.161	0.700	1.010	0.267	0.760	0.699

Fig. 10: Predicted vs Actual WaR (Appendix C6)



Finding Two: Temporal Effects

As with the Republican dataset, there was no temporal effect. This was tested against both the emotional and semantic predictors. Neither interaction was significant (Fig. 10). The absence of temporal effects for both parties suggests that any changes in the effectiveness of populist rhetoric over time are candidate- or race-specific rather than a broader trend.

Fig. 11: Temporal Model Statistics (Appendix C4)

	Coefficient	Standard Error	p-Value
Emotion x Year	0.357	0.709	0.615
Semantic x Year	0.133	1.465	0.928

Finding Three: Random Intercept and Populism

Because neither populist dimension was predictive, but the marginal R^2 was so high, there was a concern that the populist rhetoric was tied to candidate quality. However, both the emotional and semantic predictors were found to be unrelated to the random intercept (Emotion: $r = 0.058$, $p = 0.584$; Semantic: $r = 0.106$, $p = 0.319$), which is the LMER model's measure of an individual candidate quality.

Fig. 12: Random Intercept and Emotion (Appendix C5)

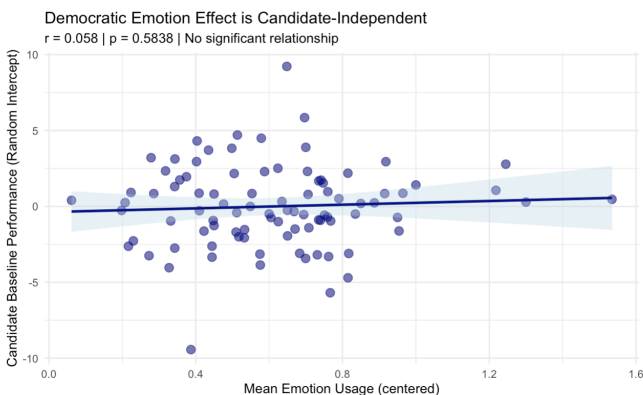
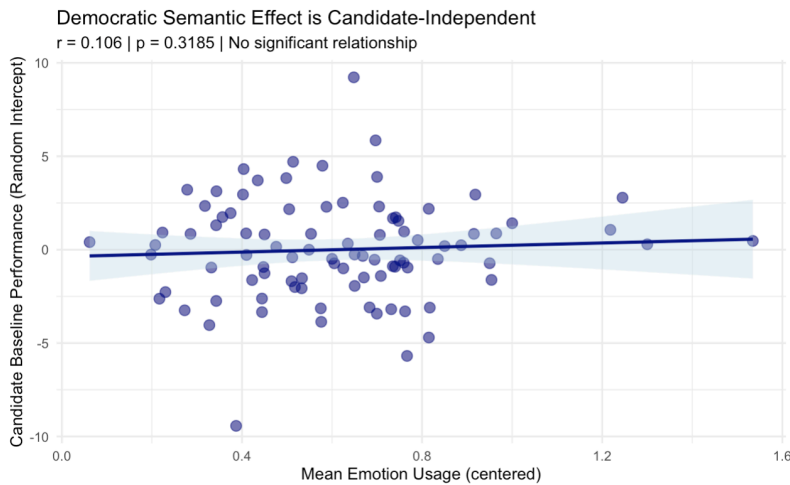


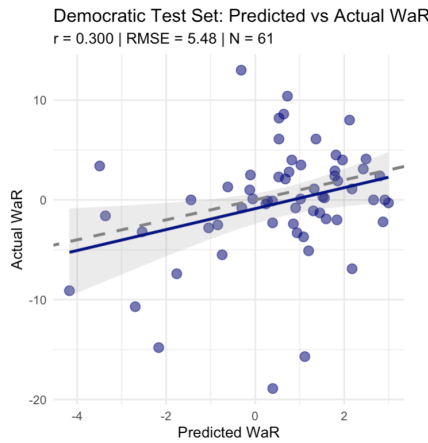
Fig. 13: Random Intercept and Semantics (Appendix C5)

Finding Four: Bootstrap Testing

The test set for the Democratic party was used to verify the model's predictive power, and the predictions were then validated using bootstrapping (Appendix E1). The model showed moderate predictive validity on the test set ($r = 0.300$, $RMSE = 5.48$), indicating that it is a somewhat reliable election predictor. As with the Republican test set, these predictions clustered around the mean, despite wider variation in actual WaR values, suggesting the model was overly conservative.

Finding Five: Percent-Based Aggregation

The percent-based aggregation showed surprising results. Despite neither the emotional nor the semantic predictors being relevant in the main model, emotion was slightly predictive in this one. While the coefficient and p-values of this new model were not enough to warrant this as an extreme difference from the main model, it is again interesting that there was a significant change when the aggregation methods changed.

Fig. 14: Test Set Predicted vs Actual WaR (Appendix E3)**Fig. 15: Percent-Based Aggregation (Appendix C2)**

	Coefficient	Standard Error	p-Value
Emotion	0.159	0.089	0.073
Semantic	-0.017	0.054	0.760

III. Cross-Party Results

Finding One: Emotion Works Similarly Across Parties

Datasets for both parties were combined into a cross-party dataset to test whether the experimental variables behaved similarly across parties (Appendix D1). Results showed that, yes, they do have similar effects, despite the Democrats not being significant (Appendix D2). In the combined model, emotion maintained significance at a level similar to that in the Republican model ($\beta = 1.282$, $p = 0.002$, $SE = 0.421$), and the semantic composite remained nonsignificant ($\beta = 1.106$, $p = 0.183$, $SE = 0.830$). The implication is that the effect of emotion is similar across parties, despite it not being a significant predictor for Democrats.

When emotion was tested for an interaction with party affiliation, the interaction had no significant effect ($\beta = 0.101$, $p = 0.924$, $SE = 1.05$) (Appendix D4). This, again, implies that Democrats are not statistically significantly distinct from Republicans in terms of emotion.

Finding Two: District Competitiveness and Emotion

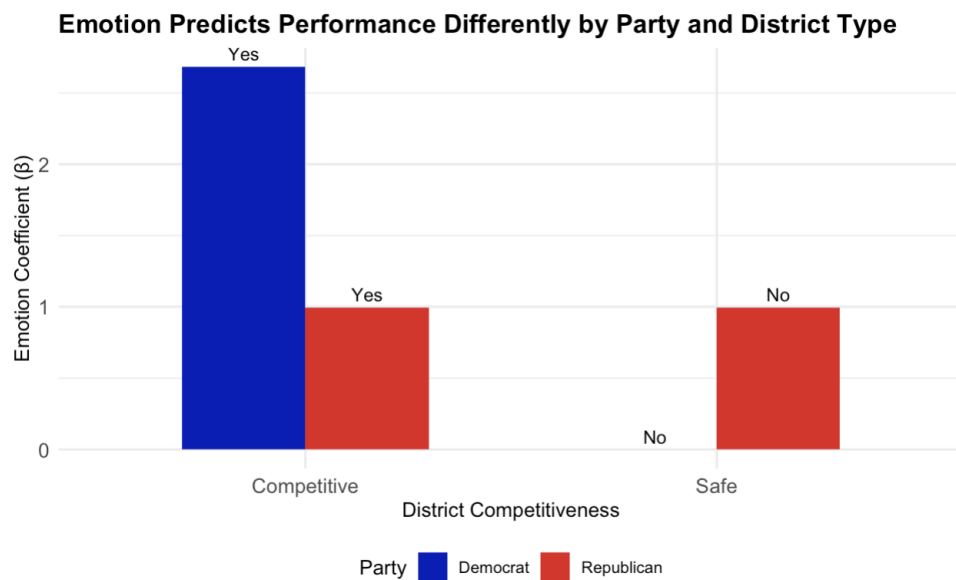
For both parties, the PVIs of each district were sorted by competitiveness: if the absolute value of the PVI exceeded 10, the district was deemed “safe” in one direction or the other. If close to zero, that district was sorted as competitive. Then, competitive and safe districts were tested for their emotion predictability.

This new model, sorted by district competitiveness, found that district safety was predictive of the relationship between emotion and WaR. For Republicans, the difference was marginal (Safe $r = 0.184$, Competitive $r = 0.209$). For Democrats, the difference was large (Safe $r = 0.065$, Competitive $r = 0.209$) (Appendix D5). This means that in competitive districts, the relationship between emotion and WaR goes from not predictive to moderately correlated. In terms of significance, the both Democrats and Republicans in safe districts had no significant relationship with emotion (respectively: $p = 0.409$; $p = 0.454$).

The similar correlations in competitive districts ($r = 0.209$ for both parties) mask important differences in the full regression models. When controlling for district partisanship, fundraising, and other factors, Democratic candidates' emotional rhetoric showed a substantially larger effect ($\beta = 2.681$) than Republicans' ($\beta = 0.995$), suggesting that while emotion operates similarly for each party, the circumstances in which emotion is impactful is party-dependent (Fig. 16). The relatively high coefficient demonstrates that for Democrats running in competitive area, having even a slightly stronger average emotion score correlates to over a 2.5 point increase in WaR. The lack of significance in safe districts suggests that this language operates at its best when candidates have a viable opponent to mobilize the emotional language against.

Fig. 16: Competitive District Output (Appendix D5)

Party	n	Coefficient	p-Value
Republican	183	0.995	0.057
Democrat	144	2.681	0.015

Fig. 17: District Safety Comparison by Party (Appendix D5)

DISCUSSION & CONCLUSION

The results of these studies revealed that there is a meaningful predictive relationship between populism and performance in campaigns. The question is what significance these findings have in the field of political science. This section will respond to the hypotheses and discuss the limitations and implications of the findings.

I. Research Questions

Question One

The first research question was whether populism predicts electoral success. In a combined model, the hypothesis was confirmed: emotion was predictive ($\beta = 1.282$, $p = 0.002$), whereas the semantic composite was not ($\beta = 1.106$, $p = 0.183$). This is qualified by the fact that this combined model assumes similarities between Democrats and Republicans, which may not be the case.⁶ The implication is that for every one-point increase in average emotional intensity, we can predict that a candidate will perform roughly 1.2 points better. Higher emotion is associated with a moderate increase in performance.

These results were confirmed to have moderate applicability when tested with a separate testing dataset. For both parties, the test set was held aside during model fitting and used to test the models, and the results showed that both party models were moderately accurate at predicting out-of-sample data (Republican $r = 0.291$; Democrat $r = 0.300$). Importantly, the results appeared to cluster near the center (Figs. 7 & 14), suggesting that the model systematically moderated the results. The predictions tended to be modest, while the actual WaR values had wide variance.

The models suggest that emotion is the dominant populist trait in predicting election results. We can predict that anxiety and emotion act as mediators. As stated previously, words without emotion are meaningless – the biggest influence happens when the audience is made to *feel* a certain way (Marcus et al., 2005). This confirms that what Gerstlé and Nai found globally, which was that emotionality and negativity had a profound effect on media coverage and results, whereas populist rhetoric was weak in its predictive nature. This model suggests

⁶ As will be shown in section two, Democrats do not have a relationship with populist language.

that while language may be a helpful tool in fostering emotion, it is not, in and of itself, predictive of any voter behavior. Emotion is what predicts outcomes, not words.

This finding aligns with research on affective decision-making (Lerner et al., 2015; Marcus et al., 2005; Brader et al., 2008), where emotional appeals bypass rational deliberation. Candidates who cultivate anxiety or anger may mobilize supporters more effectively than those who rely on policy alone.

Question Two

The second research question was whether this baseline relationship varied across contexts. Specifically, I looked at party affiliation, district competitiveness, and election year. Regarding party affiliation, Republicans use populist language more than Democrats do. This confirmed my hypothesis: Republicans show a positive relationship with emotional language ($\beta = 0.999$, $p = 0.038$) but no significant relationship with the semantic components ($\beta = 1.398$, $p = 0.160$). Democrats, in contrast, have no significant relationship with either component, though the coefficients are similar in size (Emotion: $\beta = 1.010$, $p = 0.267$; Semantic: $\beta = 0.760$, $p = 0.699$).

This was predicted due to Republicans' relationship with and influence by Trump – I predicted that language and strategy adoption by Republicans would lead to more Trumpian populist language being used within the party. These results demonstrate that the Trump effect is real. Republicans have a stronger relationship to populist rhetoric, and their vote shares can be predicted by how populist they are. As with the first hypothesis, this confirms that a global trend is applicable on a national level. Worldwide, Trump has been shown to influence the strategies of other right-wing politicians (Pérez-Curiel et al., 2021). In this study, that influence is seen in congressional candidates as well. Those who adopt the Trumpian strategy see greater success.

Additionally, the lack of predictive power between populist strategies and Democratic candidates implies that the party has undergone a shift away from traditional New Deal populism. Interestingly, in the past two decades, the Democratic Party has grown wealthier and more educated, shifting away from the working-class roots that historically have defined its base (Pew, 2024; Grossman & Hopkins, 2024). If populism is designed to appeal to the working class, then it makes sense that a wealthier, more educated Democratic Party has shied away from the populist strategy.⁷

Temporally, it was hypothesized that the predictive power of populism would decline over time due to oversaturation of the strategy. In the preliminary study, it was found that as more politicians adopted populist strategies, the predictive power of populism decreased. This was not the case with either party, disproving the hypothesis. The relationship between populist strategies and time was insignificant (Republican Emotion: $p = 0.257$; Democrat Emotion: $p = 0.615$; Democrat Semantic: $p = 0.928$), suggesting no significant change in populism's predictive power over time.

This change appears to result from a larger sample size and a more robust methodology. The preliminary study had a significantly smaller sample size, roughly half as many candidates. With the additional candidates, the effect disappeared. This disproves the “oversaturation” hypothesis originally proposed in the preliminary study. The theory was that as more candidates adopted the Trumpian populist messaging, they limited the effectiveness of the strategy. The public became desensitized to populism, and it lost relevance in the models. The current study shows that this was only an artifact of the limited sample size, and that populism (and specifically, emotionality) has not lost relevance over time for Republicans. This explains why candidates still appeal to the Trumpian populist strategy years after its introduction.

⁷ This changes when considering the district-competitiveness results, discussed in the implications section.

Finally, regarding district competitiveness, it was found that, for both parties, populist rhetoric and emotion were significantly more predictive in competitive areas than in safe ones. This supported the hypothesis, which predicted that both parties would show stronger relationships with populism in competitive areas.

The result for Democrats was quite surprising, in particular, because it contradicts the general narrative of left-wing populist candidates. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez and Zohran Mamdani both were elected in the Democratic stronghold of New York City, implying that left-wing populists can only succeed in Democratic districts. These results contradict that, suggesting that populism, as a strategy, is more successful for Democrats when they are in competitive districts. Again, this ties into the idea of the Democratic base shifting and the targets of populism. If the working class is the ideal recipient, then a competitive arena becomes the ideal location for populism on either side of the aisle.

II. Limitations

This study faced numerous limitations that may have impacted the results. First, the data collected is not the most robust, and may have caused errors down the line. By limiting the corpus to Twitter, the data were limited to candidates who had Twitter accounts. It is possible that older candidates have a weaker (or absent) Twitter presence, and older Twitter accounts may have been taken down. Conversely, younger candidates are more likely to have a robust presence on social media. Using a social media platform as the main data source skews the data towards a specific subset of politicians.

Additionally, Split Ticket's WaR metric only goes back until 2016, meaning that there was no way to run this study for candidates in the pre-Trump era of politics. This means that there is no meaningful contrast between the current state of populism and a pre-Trump populism.

Without that comparison, it is impossible to say whether Trump has *changed* politics; we can only say that these results describe the current state of affairs.

There are also methodological problems to consider. Starting with the corpus, it is unclear whether Claude is the best coder for sentiment analysis. While the LLM was given very strict instructions and closely followed them after review, the AI was given broad authority to code thousands of Tweets with no secondary coder. It is possible that, outside the Tweets checked for accuracy, Claude made systematic coding errors.

Additionally, while a number of control variables were introduced to improve accuracy, the model outputs indicated that much of this accuracy stemmed from the random intercepts, which capture how data points interact with the model. In this study, random intercepts were introduced by candidate, allowing each candidate to be adjusted along the model based on their baseline WaR performance. The need for random slopes is evident in the R^2 outputs. When accounting for overall applicability, the R^2 was roughly 0.14 for Republicans and 0.15 for Democrats, indicating that the variables explained roughly 15% of the variance in both datasets. However, when accounting for each candidate's individual intercept, the R^2 jumped to 0.54 and 0.70, respectively. This increase suggests that the majority of the explanatory power of these models comes not from the variables themselves, but from the traits of individual candidates. Many of these are not quantifiable: how do you measure a person's charisma or perceived intelligence?

Additionally, these results are not entirely generalizable. The results of the test sets revealed that the models can predict the WaR with moderate accuracy ($r \sim 0.30$ for both parties). However, the predictions were largely clustered near the mean. This suggests that the model systematically failed in its predictions by moderating towards the average. While the test results indicated moderate replicability, it is not strong enough for this model to accurately

predict all outcomes. If used for future elections, it should be known that the model will likely predict closer to the mean than is accurate.

It is also important to note that all results are correlational. While it was shown that emotion predicts WaR, causality cannot be established in a purely statistical study without a laboratory experiment. There is a possibility that strong candidates simply use more emotion naturally, rather than emotion causing electoral success.

III. Implications

Findings from these studies reveal the importance of rhetoric in elections. The way politicians speak does correlate with how they perform, particularly when their speech creates emotion in their constituents. There are two major implications to this research: how political parties use speech, and how the future study of ideologies can utilize this operationalized definition of populism.

These results highlight the inherent differences in the parties' politics. Neither party seems to care about the populist message, *per se*. But voters do care about their politicians being *fighters*, using strong language that sparks emotion.

Democrats are not populist – they are liberals. They focus on policy positions, not how great their team is, and follow the example of typical modern liberalism (Krugman, 2007). This can be seen in the emotional tenor of the populists within the party, Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, who is staunchly populist but focuses her emotional tenor on positive emotion (Stieg, 2020). This strategy changes in competitive areas, where Democratic voters are surrounded by the other party. In that environment, the in-group effect is strong. Voters want to hear how their team is great and how the other is terrible.

This is not the dynamic for Republicans. It seems that for their base, the thing that matters the most is not policy, but how much they hate the other team. Donald Trump famously reneges on his promises, yet remains highly popular (McGraw et al., 2026; Gallup, 2026). This is because, despite his broken promises, he never stops attacking the other side. The results show that Republicans care about populism only insofar as it incorporates attacks on their enemies. In tough districts, Democrats are the same way. What is clear is that under no circumstances, in either party, does the *content* of the speech correspond to performance.

This is in direct contrast to how political pundits discuss Democratic politics. The idea recently has been that Democratic candidates must adhere to a more moderate brand of politics to avoid alienating less extreme voters (Arm, 2026; Downs, 2026; Remnick, 2025). This brand of centrism is about rejecting populist rhetoric and left-wing policy positions. These results contradict that interpretation of the 2024 election, showing that the content of Democrats' language is not important. Whether they are using their platform to support far-left populist policies, what matters in competitive areas is whether the candidate is willing to fight. Both parties could benefit from further investigation into the role that language plays in their election outcomes.

Beyond the political implications of this research, the methodology should be utilized in future research into political ideology. The literature review in this paper discussed the notorious difficulty in operationalizing populism (and ideologies, broadly) for research purposes. This study proves that unifying theories around a performance-based definition of ideology allows for a simple study of complex topics.

Much of the research into populism has been based on the work of Moffitt and Tormey, who described populism as a rhetorical style with distinctive performative features. Their definition incorporates the core elements used to construct the semantic composite (people-centrism, anti-elitism, and anti-intellectual language). However, measuring how these

rhetorical features translate to electoral outcomes has remained challenging. This study operationalizes populism through observable communicative dimensions rather than attempting to quantify underlying beliefs.

This study adopts a pragmatic methodological approach: rather than debating whether ideologies "are" performances, we examine how populist ideology is communicated and recognized through observable linguistic features. This operationalization aligns with research by Gerstlé and Nai (2019), which demonstrates that emotional communication and rhetorical style predict electoral outcomes more reliably than attempts to measure underlying ideological conviction.

Rather than continuously acknowledging the difficulties in defining populism, future research should adopt methodological approaches that focus on observable, measurable communicative features. This study demonstrates that examining how populist ideology is linguistically performed—through distinctive rhetorical patterns and emotional appeals—simplifies the research process immensely and creates a concise, replicable methodology.

These findings reshape how we understand populism in politics, as well as how we research it. As populism becomes increasingly mainstream, we need to refine our understanding of how it operates, as well as our techniques used to perform research on it. Researchers and political strategists should recognize that it is emotionality, not semantic content, that drives electoral predictive power. For Democrats, this means understanding that adopting moderate policy positions does not predict electoral success independent of emotional intensity. Instead, electoral success requires cultivating emotional intensity in their rhetoric, regardless of policy positioning. For Republicans, the consistent predictive power of emotion validates their continued reliance on affective rhetoric. For researchers concerned with democratic integrity, understanding that negative emotion is predictive of election results can

inform interventions aimed at reducing affective polarization and emotional escalation in campaigns. Regardless of one's position, populism seems to be here to stay. Understanding how it operates and defining it clearly is essential to a political era where populism dominates.

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